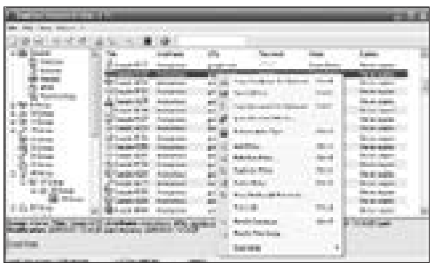
5.5 Password Management

Security and authenticity are gaining increasing importance across the spectrum of life—personal and business, alike. With this the focus naturally has to be on the tools that make it possible for us to protect our critical and vital information and documents. Here, we look at some of the most prominent players in the password segment of open source movement.

5.5.1 KeePass Password Safe (http:// keepass.sourceforge.net)

KeePass databases are encrypted using the much-respected AES and Twofish symmetric ciphers. Passwords are hashed using SHA-256, and kept in an encrypted form in the KeePass process memory. The rationale is that even if Windows caches the KeePass process to disk, the user's passwords wouldn't be revealed.



You can even carry KeePass on a USB disk

The tool is the first password management utility that uses security-enhanced password edit controls. None of the available password spies work against the controls used in KeePass. The passwords entered in these controls aren't even visible in the process memory of KeePass.

The working scheme of KeePass is really novel. One master password decrypts the complete database. Alternatively, you can use key-disks, as they provide better security than master passwords in most cases. For even more security one can combine the above two methods: the database then requires the key-disk and the password in order to be unlocked. Even if you lose your key-disk, the database would remain secure.